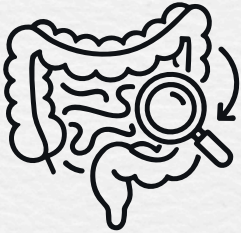


Methods of Acquiring Knowledge



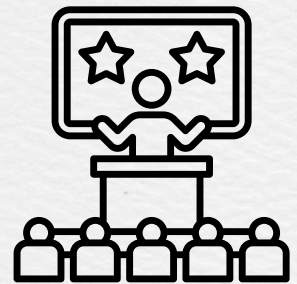
1. Intuition



When we use our intuition, we are relying on our guts, our emotions, and/or our instincts to guide us. Rather than examining facts or using rational thought, intuition involves believing what feels true.

2. Authority

One of the most common methods of acquiring knowledge involves accepting new ideas because an authority figure says its true. Much of the information we acquire is through authority because we don't have time to question and independently research every piece of knowledge. But we can learn to evaluate the credentials of authority figures, to evaluate the methods they used to arrive at their conclusions, and evaluate whether they have any reasons to mislead us.



3. Rationalism

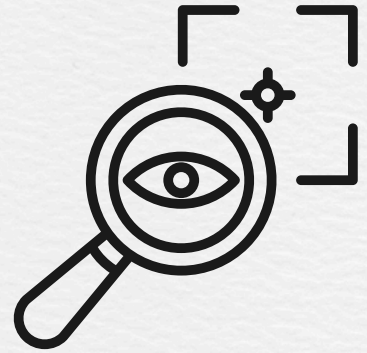
Rationalism involves using logic and reasoning to acquire new knowledge. Using this method premises are stated and logical rules are followed to arrive at sound conclusions. The problem with this method is that if the premises are wrong or there is an error in logic then the conclusion will not be valid.



Methods of Acquiring Knowledge

4. Empiricism

Empiricism involves acquiring knowledge through observation and experience. We are limited in what we can experience and observe and our senses can deceive us. Moreover, our prior experiences can alter the way we perceive events. Nevertheless, empiricism is at the heart of the scientific method. Science relies on observations. But not just any observations, science relies on structured observations which is known as systematic empiricism.



5. Scientific Method

The scientific method is a process of systematically collecting and evaluating evidence to test ideas and answer questions. While scientists may use **intuition, authority, rationalism, and empiricism** to generate new ideas they don't stop there. Scientists go a step further by using systematic empiricism to make careful observations under various controlled conditions in order to test their ideas, using rationalism to arrive at valid conclusions.

